

Business Impact Governance Levels (BIGL)

Status: Working draft for companion use with the IASEAI policy document **Purpose:** To provide a simple, consequence-based method for selecting proportionate governance for AI-supported activity.

This is derived from His Majesty's Governments previous publications on Business Impact levels (BIL) for security assurance and classification in official documents.

1. Principle

BIGL applies to the **activity and its potential consequences**, not to the AI model, platform, or interface itself. The same AI system may therefore be used at different BIGL levels for different tasks.

The method adapts the logic of the former HMG Business Impact Level approach: assess impact in the relevant business context, consider more than one impact category where necessary, and use the most significant credible consequence to determine the required level of control.

Core chain:

Business impact → BIGL → required controls → records → assurance

BIGL is intended to complement, not replace, an organisation's existing governance, risk, compliance, quality, security, or professional management systems.

Ethical and moral boundaries: BIGL does not assume that every activity can be made acceptable through additional controls. Organisations should identify ethical, moral, legal, and professional red lines beyond which an AI-supported activity shall not proceed without explicit prohibition, escalation, or authorised exception.

2. BIGL levels

BIGL	Governance state	Typical consequence	Typical use	Minimum governance expectation
1	Ad-hoc	Negligible or readily reversible	Routine chat, drafting, brainstorming, low-consequence assistance	Normal user judgement; no special record beyond ordinary business practice
2	Deliberated (PDCA)	Limited but meaningful	Analysis, recommendations or drafting that may influence work but remains readily reviewable	Purpose and constraints made explicit; human review; significant assumptions or limitations noted
3	Governed (CIPDA/ROMER)	Material business, legal, financial, evidential, operational or stakeholder consequence	Consequential analysis, decision support, regulated work, evidence preparation, material external communication	Primer or equivalent structured instruction; accountable owner; defined controls; direct chronology and session records; retained evidence; Scorecard review; proportionate assurance
4	Prescriptive (Process or workflow)	Serious, potentially irreversible, safety-critical, rights-affecting, highly regulated or major public-interest consequence	High-impact decisions, critical evidence, safety/security functions, major regulated or fiduciary activity	Prescribed procedure; constrained discretion; formal approval/escalation; comprehensive traceability; ROMER; Scorecard; independent or functionally separate assurance where appropriate

Out of scope / no material impact: Activities with no meaningful consequence need not be assigned a BIGL level unless organisational policy requires one.

3. Impact assessment attributes

BIGL should be determined by considering the attributes relevant to the activity. Not every attribute will apply in every case. Where more than one attribute applies, use the **highest credible business impact** unless a documented organisational rule provides otherwise.

Attribute	BIGL 1 — Ad-hoc	BIGL 2 — Deliberated	BIGL 3 — Governed	BIGL 4 — Prescriptive
People, safety, and wellbeing	No material effect	Minor inconvenience or readily recoverable effect	Material effect on an individual or identifiable group	Serious harm, loss of liberty, safety-critical or potentially life-affecting consequence
Rights, privacy, and fairness	No material rights effect	Limited or readily correctable effect	Material privacy, fairness, entitlement, or rights consequence	Severe, systemic, irreversible, or legally protected-rights consequence
Ethical / moral acceptability	No material ethical concern.	Limited or readily resolvable ethical concern.	Material ethical, dignity, fairness or professional concern requiring explicit review.	Activity approaches or crosses a recognised ethical, moral, legal, or professional red line and requires prohibition, formal escalation, or specific authorisation.
Financial / economic	Trivial or absorbed in routine operations	Limited loss or rework	Material loss, liability, or commercial consequence	Severe financial loss, solvency, fiduciary, or systemic economic consequence
Legal / regulatory / evidential	No material reliance	Internal or preliminary use	Material compliance, contractual, evidential, or legal reliance	Court-critical, regulatory-critical, enforcement, liberty, or major liability consequence
Operations / service continuity	No meaningful disruption	Local, short-lived, or readily recoverable disruption	Material degradation or interruption of important services	Critical, prolonged, widespread, or safety-related service failure
Trust / reputation / public interest	Little or no external effect	Limited stakeholder concern	Material loss of confidence or reputational damage	Severe or widespread loss of trust, public-interest, or institutional legitimacy consequence
Decision integrity	Output is optional or exploratory	Output informs but does not determine a decision	Output materially shapes a consequential decision	Output may determine or constrain a high-consequence decision unless tightly controlled
Reversibility / remediation	Easily undone	Correctable with limited cost or delay	Difficult, costly, or consequential to reverse	Irreversible, time-critical or remediation cannot reliably restore the position
Scale / aggregation	Single user or isolated task	Small group or limited dataset	Multiple people, records, systems, or repeated deployment	Large-scale, systemic, population-level or aggregation materially increases consequence

Attribute	BIGL 1 — Ad-hoc	BIGL 2 — Deliberated	BIGL 3 — Governed	BIGL 4 — Prescriptive
Autonomy / discretion	Human directs each step	AI proposes; human decides	AI undertakes material analytical or operational steps within defined bounds	Agentic or automated action with significant discretion, external effects, or limited opportunity for intervention

4. Control expectations by BIGL

Control area	BIGL 1	BIGL 2	BIGL 3	BIGL 4
Instruction	Prompt	Prompt or light Primer	Primer or equivalent structured brief	Controlled Primer / prescribed procedure
Human responsibility	User	Named reviewer where needed	Named accountable owner	Named accountable owner plus approval/escalation authority
Planning	Informal	Purpose and constraints stated	Planned controls, acceptance criteria and evidence needs	Formal controls, limits, approvals, and contingency/escalation arrangements
Chronology / logs	Ordinary business record	Material decisions noted	Direct before/after chronology for material actions; session and system records retained	Comprehensive chronology, logs, approvals, deviations, and change records
Traceability	Not normally required	Enough to support review	Sufficient to reconstruct material inputs, actions, decisions, and outputs	Full or near-full reconstruction expected, subject to lawful constraints
Scorecard	Optional	Optional / light	Required	Required and formally reviewed
ROMER	Not required	Optional	Used where business impact, evidential need or assurance justifies it	Required unless an equivalent controlled assurance record is mandated
Independent assurance	No	Usually no	As proportionate to consequence	Expected where practical and material
Improvement feedback	Informal	Capture useful lessons	Feed exceptions, findings, and nonconformities into management review	Formal corrective action, management review, and conformity evidence

Red-line review — Required where relevant: confirm that the intended activity does not breach defined legal, ethical, moral, professional, or organisational boundaries before approval.

5. Assignment rules

1. **Classify the activity, not the technology.** Chat, agentic AI, API use and embedded AI can each fall at any BIGL level depending on consequence.
2. **Assess credible consequence before controls.** Do not reduce the level merely because strong controls are already planned.
3. **Use relevant attributes only.** It is neither necessary nor useful to force every activity through every row.

4. **Apply red lines before proportionality.** Where an activity conflicts with a defined legal, ethical, moral, professional, or organisational red line, the activity shall not proceed merely because additional controls could be applied. It must be stopped, escalated, or specifically authorised in accordance with the applicable requirement.
5. **Use the highest credible impact where several attributes apply.** Aggregation, scale, or interaction between impacts may justify escalation.
6. **Record the rationale for BIGL 3 and BIGL 4.** The justification should be intelligible to a competent reviewer without requiring the originating AI system.
7. **Escalate when conditions change.** A task that begins at one level may move upward if scope, autonomy, data, consequence, or external reliance increases.
8. **Organisational rules prevail where stricter.** BIGL is a governance aid and should integrate with existing legal, regulatory, professional, security and quality requirements.

6. Worked examples

Example activity	Indicative BIGL	Reason
Deliberately withheld	Deliberately withheld	Deliberately withheld
Deliberately withheld	Deliberately withheld	Deliberately withheld
Deliberately withheld	Deliberately withheld	Deliberately withheld
Deliberately withheld	Deliberately withheld	Deliberately withheld

7. AI regeneration note

This document is intentionally structured so that an AI system can regenerate or adapt the tables without relying on hidden context.

When regenerating BIGL, preserve these rules:

- BIGL is **consequence-based**, not technology-based.
- Preserve the four states: **Ad-hoc, Deliberated, Governed, Prescriptive**.
- Determine level from the **highest credible relevant impact**, not an average score.
- Keep **business impact** separate from the **controls used to manage it**.
- Controls become more structured as BIGL increases.
- For BIGL 3, retain a direct chronology and sufficient evidence for reconstruction.
- For BIGL 4, require ROMER or a demonstrably equivalent assurance record, together with stronger approval and independent assurance.
- The Scorecard is an **inward-looking governance lens** used to test whether the selected state, controls, records and assurance remain sufficient.
- The record should remain intelligible to a competent human reviewer and should not depend on hidden, encoded or AI-only interpretation.
- Where organisational, legal, regulatory or professional requirements are stricter, those requirements take precedence.

Minimal machine-readable schema

```
bigl:
  applies_to: activity
  basis: highest_credible_business_impact
  levels:
    1: Ad-hoc
    2: Deliberated
```

3: Governed

4: Prescriptive

impact_attributes:

- people_safety_wellbeing
- rights_privacy_fairness
- financial_economic
- legal_regulatory_evidential
- operations_service_continuity
- trust_reputation_public_interest
- decision_integrity
- reversibility_remediation
- scale_aggregation
- autonomy_discretion

mandatory_escalation:

bigl_3:

- accountable_owner
- structured_instruction
- direct_chronology
- retained_evidence
- scorecard
- proportionate_assurance

bigl_4:

- prescribed_procedure
- formal_approval_or_escalation
- comprehensive_traceability
- romer_or_equivalent
- scorecard
- independent_or_separate_assurance_where_practicable

8. Origin and relationship to earlier Business Impact Level thinking

BIGL is informed by the consequence-based logic of the former HMG Business Impact Level tables, but it is not a reproduction of that scheme. The earlier approach assessed business impact across relevant sectors and treated impacts such as confidentiality, integrity and availability independently. BIGL generalises that principle for AI-supported work and couples assessed consequence directly to governance, recording and assurance expectations.

The historic HMG material should therefore be treated as an intellectual and methodological antecedent, not as a current normative authority for BIGL.

Working status: Draft for research, policy development and repository review. Not an ISO, government or regulatory standard.

Methodological antecedent: HMG IA Standard No. 1, Business Impact Level Tables, Issue 3.5 (October 2009). BIGL adapts the consequence-based assessment logic; it does not reproduce or claim current authority for that scheme.